

Time, Speed, and Acceleration in Modern Life

How Dis-Ease Is Created

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कालार्थकर्मणां योगो हीनमिथ्यातिमात्रकः । सम्यग्योगश्च विज्ञेयो रोगारोग्यैकारणम् ॥

--- अष्टाङ्गहृदयम् सूत्रस्थान (१.१९)

Deficient, improper, or excessive engagement with time, sensory experience, and activity causes disease; their proper engagement is the cause of health.

We usually think about health in terms of what we do: what we eat, how much we exercise, how much we sleep, and which habits we avoid. Gym. Protein. Calories. Steps. Heart rate. BMI. Blood pressure. Sleep score. Supplements. Wearables. Recovery. Full body check-up. We measure, track, optimize, and quantify almost everything. If the numbers look right, we assume health will follow.

Āyurveda asks us to notice something far more subtle, yet far more powerful: not merely what we do, but how we live in time. The verse above from *Vāgbhaṭa* offers a remarkably broad principle. Health and disease are influenced by our relationship with *kāla* (time), *artha* (the objects of sensory experience), and *karma* (our actions and activities). Importantly, the problem is not simply that we do too much. *Vāgbhaṭa* identifies three possibilities: *hīna*, too little; *mithyā*, in an inappropriate manner; and *atimātra*, too much. Health arises from *samyag-yoga*, an appropriate engagement. Something beneficial in the right amount can become harmful when excessive. Something appropriate at one time may be inappropriate at another. Even something inherently necessary can become a source of disturbance when it is pursued without regard to the body's capacity and rhythm. This principle becomes particularly relevant when we examine modern life.

Linear vs. Biological Time: The Problem of Living at the Wrong Speed

Modern society runs almost entirely on **linear, measurable, and quantifiable time**. Hours are divided into appointments, meetings, deadlines, targets, and schedules. Productivity is measured by how much can be accomplished within a given period. We are encouraged to save time, optimize time, compress time, and increasingly, to do several things within the same unit of time. Speed itself has become a virtue. A faster response appears more efficient; a faster meal appears more convenient; a faster workday more productive. But **the human body does not operate according to a stopwatch**. The body lives through rhythms. We wake and sleep, become hungry and satisfied, digest food, expend energy, recover, repair, and adapt. These processes have their own temporal organization. Digestion cannot simply be accelerated because we have another meeting. Sleep cannot be compressed indefinitely without consequences. Recovery cannot be demanded according to a deadline. Mental clarity cannot always be produced by simply increasing effort. There is therefore a fundamental difference between **clock time and biological time**. The clock can move at exactly the same speed every day. The body cannot. Its needs and capacities fluctuate with the time of day, season, age, activity, nourishment, and countless other conditions. This is where the Āyurvedic understanding of *kāla* becomes especially interesting. *Kāla* is not merely a number displayed on a clock. Time is experienced through rhythms and changing conditions. Āyurveda consequently gives importance to daily routine, seasonal adaptation, appropriate timing of food, sleep, activity, and rest. These are not merely traditional habits; they represent an attempt to place human activity within the rhythms in which the organism naturally functions.

The problem with modern life may therefore not be only **how much we do, but how quickly and continuously we do it**. Consider an ordinary day. We wake up and immediately reach for information. We eat while looking at a screen. We move rapidly between emails, messages, lectures, meetings, and multiple unfinished tasks. We expect instant responses and provide instant responses. We work while eating, think about work while resting, and often remain mentally engaged even after the physical workday has ended. Every pause becomes an opportunity to consume another piece of information. None of these activities is necessarily harmful in isolation. The difficulty arises

when constant stimulation and acceleration become the normal condition of life. This is precisely where Vāgbhaṭa's distinction between *hīna*, *mithyā*, and *atimātra* becomes useful. Too little activity can be problematic, but so can excessive activity. Activity performed at the wrong time or in the wrong manner can also become problematic. Thus, the Āyurvedic question is not simply, "Am I doing something healthy?" It is also, "Am I doing it in the right amount, at the right time, and in the right manner?"

Eating is necessary, but eating hurriedly, without attention, or at irregular times is a different experience from eating calmly and appropriately. Work is necessary, but continuous work without recovery is different from work interspersed with adequate rest. Sensory experience is unavoidable, but uninterrupted stimulation is different from periods in which the senses are allowed to settle. The issue, therefore, is not activity versus inactivity. It is appropriate engagement versus dysregulated engagement.

When the Mind Moves Faster Than the Body

Stress is often described as an emotional condition. We say that someone is stressed because they have too much work, too many responsibilities, or too many problems. But there is another dimension to stress: **the speed at which the mind moves through those experiences**. The mind can be physically sitting in one place while psychologically moving far into the future. It anticipates the next meeting, worries about tomorrow's deadline, plans the next task, checks the next notification, and rehearses conversations that have not yet happened. The body, meanwhile, remains where it is. **The body digests NOW. It sleeps now. It recovers now. It breathes now.** But the mind may constantly be anticipating what comes next. When this becomes habitual, even periods of physical rest may fail to become genuine rest. A person may lie in bed for eight hours while the mind continues racing, or sit quietly for ten minutes while mentally moving through dozens of unfinished tasks. **The body is stationary, but the mind is still accelerating.**

This gives us another way of understanding the Āyurvedic idea of *mithyā-yoga*, or inappropriate engagement. The problem is not necessarily the presence of thought, ambition, planning, or activity. These are essential aspects of human life. The difficulty arises when the manner of engagement becomes persistently excessive or disconnected from the body's capacity for recovery. This may also explain why a person can appear highly successful while gradually becoming less healthy. Long working hours, irregular meals, late nights, continuous mental engagement, and minimal genuine rest may produce impressive short-term results while slowly exhausting the capacity for recovery. Āyurveda does not ask us to reject ambition or productive work. Rather, it asks us to recognize that the organism has limits. A system can compensate for stress for a considerable period, but **compensation is not the same as health**. When demands repeatedly exceed the capacity for recovery, the consequences may eventually become visible as disturbed sleep, persistent fatigue, digestive disturbance, reduced mental clarity, irritability, or other forms of dysfunction. Disease, from this perspective, need not be imagined as something that suddenly appears from nowhere. It may be the eventual expression of a pattern that has been developing for a long time.

Learning to Live in Biological Time

Slowing down does not mean doing nothing, nor abandoning ambition, intellectual work, or responsibility. It means reducing unnecessary agitation and allowing the mind and body to operate without being constantly pushed beyond their natural rhythm. Sometimes restoration is remarkably ordinary: eating without a screen, walking without answering messages, finishing one task before beginning another, or simply allowing a period of genuine quiet. These small pauses create something increasingly rare in modern life: **a period in which nothing demands an immediate response**.

The deeper lesson is not that speed is always bad. But, we have become skilled at asking whether something is productive, efficient, or beneficial, but less accustomed to asking whether it is appropriately timed and integrated into the rhythm of life. Modern life has given us extraordinary control over time, yet perhaps at a cost. We have learned to save minutes while losing the ability to pause. We have learned to increase productivity while reducing recovery. We have learned to fill every interval while becoming increasingly uncomfortable with stillness... Ask yourself these disconcerting questions: *Am I merely using my time efficiently, or am I living in harmony with it? Is my body living at the same speed as my mind?* Again, let's keep the answers to yourself!